

Cover story **BJP**



The party faithful could relate with senior leaders who sought an internal debate on the reasons behind the defeat.

lence and demanded inner party debate on the reasons for the unprecedented defeat, the party's core constituents connected with them. Their credentials were impeccable: all of them were top performers in the Vajpayee government, were torch bearers of reforms and represented the party's modern face. And unlike those who held the party in a vice-like grip without ever having won a popular election, two of the three leaders had successfully fought Lok Sabha elections.

Their query, which so far has elicited no response, is simple: when it is time to take stock and introspect, why is the leadership running away? Shourie and Jaswant particularly had

reasons to be livid since both were staunch supporters of Advani, yet were kept out of the party's election machinery. It is this attitude of those who led the party to its worst humiliation that the three senior leaders are determined to fight. Jaswant was blunt in his two-page letter to Rajnath in Sanskritised Hindi. "Our party resembles a football ground where no rules apply and anyone can kick anyone else without any fear of punishment," he averred. Sinha went a step further and in a five-page letter to the 11 members of the core group sought a debate on the issues, policies, and faces that were projected during the election and which boomeranged.

He sought the resignation of all the office-bearers of the party for the electoral debacle, but when no one was ready to oblige, he offered his own as vice-president, which Rajnath promptly accepted.

They found support from ex-party chief M.M. Joshi and former Uttarakhand chief minister B.S. Koshiyari. Now, as the leadership gets ready to hold its first post-election meeting of the 130-member national executive, the challengers are set to force a wider debate on the debacle. The volcano, as Sushma termed it, is waiting to erupt. But the tired and the discredited will most likely outlive the volcanic eruption and continue to demoralise.



The challengers

YASHWANT, JASWANT,
SHOURIE, JOSHI AND
KOSHIYARI

SINHA

JASWANT

SHOURIE

JOSHI